BELLE MEADE · GREEN HILLS · FOREST HILLS · BRENTWOOD · FRANKLIN

The Nashville *Off-Market* Playbook

How private and coming-soon homes really trade in Middle Tennessee — and how $1.5M+ buyers get the first look.

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PRESENTED BY

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FOREWORD

The homes you never see on Zillow.

Some of Middle Tennessee's most interesting $1.5M+ homes are shown privately before they ever reach the public portals. A seller wants privacy, wants to test a price quietly, or simply doesn't want a public days-on-market clock. For a buyer, that creates a window: a chance to see a home, and sometimes to negotiate, before the broader market shows up.

“Off-market” is also one of the most misunderstood phrases in real estate. It is not a secret list, and it is not a back door around the rules. It is a set of specific, regulated ways a seller can choose to market a home — and the buyers who see those homes first are the ones whose agents are connected, prepared, and asked early.

This playbook explains how private sales work in Middle Tennessee today, what the rules actually allow, where these homes tend to surface, and the step-by-step system I use to get my buyers the first look — along with the risks you should weigh before buying any home that hasn't been tested on the open market.

> A NOTE FROM JASON
>
> *“The first look is rarely about luck. It goes to the buyer whose agent already knows exactly what they want, and who is ready to move the day the right home comes up.”*

1,191	263	40 days
ACTIVE $1.5M+ LISTINGS DAVIDSON & WILLIAMSON	$1.5M+ HOMES UNDER CONTRACT RIGHT NOW	MEDIAN LIST-TO-CONTRACT $1.5M+ · LAST 6 MONTHS

Realtracs MLS, residential, list price $1.5M+, Davidson and Williamson counties, as of October 19, 2026.

SECTION ONE

What “off-market” actually means.

When agents say a home is off-market, they usually mean one of three different things. Each has different rules, and each gives a buyer a different kind of opportunity.

TIER ONE

Office & private exclusives

The seller chooses not to put the home on the MLS for public marketing at all. It is shared inside one brokerage — at Compass, through the Private Exclusives network — and agents bring it to their buyers one at a time. These are the quietest sales in the market, and the hardest to see without a connected agent.

TIER TWO

Coming soon & delayed marketing

The home is filed with the MLS, but the seller delays public advertising — the syndication to Zillow and other sites — for a period set by the local MLS. Other agents can see it and tell their clients; the general public can't yet. On Compass, a Coming Soon home appears on Compass.com before the wider launch.

TIER THREE

Not listed — yet

An owner who would sell for the right offer but hasn't signed a listing agreement. These opportunities come from relationships: agents, builders, attorneys and neighbors who know who is thinking about a move. They are rare, and they take patience.

> THE PLAIN-ENGLISH RULE
>
> Once a listing is marketed publicly, it must be filed with the MLS within one business day. One-to-one conversations between agents don't count as public marketing. That is why private homes are shared buyer by buyer — never as a blast list.

SECTION TWO

The rules behind private sales.

The National Association of REALTORS® keeps its **Clear Cooperation Policy**: a listing that is publicly marketed has to be filed with the MLS within one business day. In March 2025 NAR added **Multiple Listing Options for Sellers**, giving sellers two formal ways to keep a home out of public view, and required MLSs to put them in place by September 30, 2025.

OPTION	ON THE MLS?	WHO SEES IT
Office exclusive	Filed, but not shared	Agents inside the listing brokerage and their clients
Delayed marketing	Filed and shared	All MLS agents and their clients; no public portals until the delay ends
Full public listing	Filed and shared	Everyone, including Zillow and other sites

Source: National Association of REALTORS®, Multiple Listing Options for Sellers (effective March 25, 2025). The length of a delayed-marketing period is set by each local MLS.

For either private option, the seller signs a disclosure acknowledging what they are giving up — mainly exposure to every buyer at once. Realtracs, the Middle Tennessee MLS, applies these options under its own rules, which can change; I confirm the current details on every private home we pursue.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU AS A BUYER

- Private homes are legitimate, rule-bound listings — and you deserve the same disclosures and diligence you'd get on any sale.
- You see them through an agent who is in the network and asks early, one listing at a time.
- Fewer competing buyers can mean more room on price and terms — but also less public price discovery, so comparable sales matter even more.

SECTION THREE

Why sellers choose to sell quietly.

Understanding the seller's motive is how a buyer wins a private sale. In the $1.5M+ market, sellers usually go private for one of a handful of reasons — and each one tells you what kind of offer will land.

- **Privacy.** High-profile owners, executives and families who don't want photos of their home on public portals. Discretion and a smooth process matter as much as price.
- **Price testing.** A seller wants feedback before committing to a public price. An early, credible offer can set the terms before anyone else sees the home.
- **No public history.** Days on market and price cuts follow a listing forever. Sellers who want to avoid that record are often motivated to deal with a prepared buyer.
- **Timing.** A relocation, a new build, or an estate. These sellers value certainty: clean financing, a flexible close, or a lease-back.
- **Still deciding.** Some owners would move for the right offer but haven't fully committed. Patience and a respectful approach win these.

2.9%	20%	30%
HIGHER CLOSE PRICE FOR COMPASS PRE-MARKETED HOMES	FASTER TO CONTRACT	LESS LIKELY TO TAKE A PRICE CUT

Compass national data for 2024, comparing listings pre-marketed as Private Exclusive and/or Coming Soon with those that weren't. Compass notes results vary by market and that correlation is not causation. These figures describe outcomes for sellers — a reminder that a private sale isn't automatically a discount for the buyer.

A NOTE FROM JASON

"The best private deals I've seen weren't the cheapest offers. They were the offers that solved the seller's real problem — timing, privacy, or certainty."

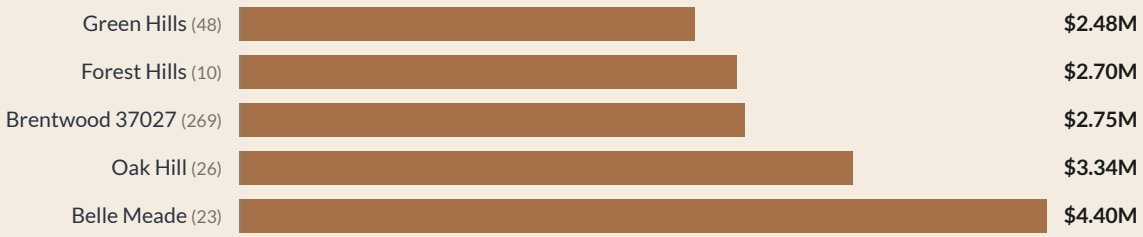
SECTION FOUR

Why the first look matters this fall.

The $1.5M+ market in Davidson and Williamson counties is balanced: about 5.8 months of supply, with 1,191 homes for sale against roughly 206 closings a month. That gives buyers choice — but the best-priced homes still move fast. The typical $1.5M+ home that sold in the last six months went under contract in 40 days and closed at 98.3% of its list price.

Median sale price of $2M+ closings, where private homes often surface

Rolling 12 months · Realtracs MLS data via Nashville Home Guru · number of $2M+ sales in parentheses



Where privacy is prized: Belle Meade and Forest Hills have scarce inventory and long-tenured owners, so homes there often change hands quietly. Brentwood's gated communities and Franklin's estate neighborhoods see new construction offered to builders' and agents' buyer lists before public launch. Green Hills offers the most $2M+ choice in Nashville, which makes timing — not access — the edge there.

Where buyers hold leverage: Above $3M, supply runs past nine months and contracts take longer. A private conversation with a seller who has been quietly testing price can be the best moment to negotiate.

Market figures: Realtracs MLS, list price $1.5M+, as of October 19, 2026; months of supply is our calculation. $3M+ supply: Realtracs listing exports via Nashville Homes, June–September 2026.

SECTION FIVE

The first-look system.

Getting the first look on a private home is a process, not a password. These are the six steps I run for every buyer who wants access before the public market.

01 · A PRECISE BUYER BRIEF

Neighborhoods, price band, lot size, must-haves, deal-breakers and timeline, written down. Agents can't match you to a private home if the description of what you want is vague.

02 · PROOF YOU CAN CLOSE

A jumbo or portfolio pre-approval, or a current proof-of-funds letter. Private sellers choose buyers they trust to close; this is what earns you the call.

03 · NETWORK OUTREACH

I watch Compass Private Exclusives and Coming Soon listings, MLS delayed-marketing listings, and builder pipelines, and I talk directly with the agents who list in your target neighborhoods.

04 · ONE-TO-ONE MATCHES

When a home fits your brief, I bring it to you individually — details, photos and context — never as a mass list. That's how the rules require private homes to be shared, and it's how sellers want them shown.

05 · FAST, PRIVATE PREVIEWS

A showing within a day or two when possible, or a live video walkthrough if you're out of town. Speed matters: private homes often go public, or to another buyer, within weeks.

06 · AN OFFER BUILT FOR THE SELLER

Pricing from closed comparable sales, plus the terms that matter to this particular seller — timing, certainty, privacy — with full inspection and diligence protections for you.

> **A NOTE FROM JASON**
>
> *"When a private home comes up, the agent with a ready, qualified buyer makes the first call. My job is to make sure that buyer is you."*

SECTION SIX

Winning a private sale — without overpaying.

A private home hasn't been tested by the open market, so there is no bidding history to anchor price. That cuts both ways. Here is how to compete for the home while protecting yourself.

BUILD THE OFFER

- Price from the last 90 days of closed sales, not from nearby asking prices.
- Lead with what the seller values: a flexible close, a lease-back, or a quiet process.
- Show strength: pre-approval or proof of funds attached, meaningful earnest money.
- Keep your protections: inspection, survey and appraisal rights sized to the property.
- Ask what is included — furnishings, art and fixtures are often negotiable in private sales.
- Get the seller's disclosures and HOA documents before you're committed.

WEIGH THE TRADE-OFFS

- **Less price discovery.** Without public offers, it's easier to pay too much. Insist on a comp analysis.
- **Less time.** Private windows are short; know your limits before you tour.
- **Fewer choices at once.** You may compare one private home against the public market rather than against other private homes.
- **Same diligence.** A private sale should never mean skipping inspections or title work.

> **THE HONEST ANSWER**
>
> Will a private home be cheaper? Sometimes — usually when the seller values speed, privacy or certainty over squeezing out the last dollar. Sometimes it's priced at or above the market. A good advisor will tell you which one you're looking at.

SECTION SEVEN

Your readiness checklist & common questions.

- Written buyer brief: areas, price band, must-haves.
- Jumbo or portfolio pre-approval, or proof of funds dated within 30 days.
- Every decision-maker available to tour or join a video walkthrough.
- Your walk-away price and timeline decided in advance.
- Inspector, attorney and lender lined up.
- LLC or trust documents ready if you're buying through an entity.

FREQUENTLY ASKED

Is buying off-market legal and safe? Yes. Office exclusives and delayed marketing are formal options under NAR and MLS rules, with seller disclosures required. You get the same contract, inspections and title protections as any other purchase.

Do I need a Compass agent? Compass Private Exclusives are shared through the Compass network, so a Compass agent sees them first. Delayed-marketing listings on the MLS are visible to any MLS agent.

Can you send me a list of off-market homes? No — and you should be wary of anyone who does. Private homes are shared one at a time with buyers they fit. That's the rule, and it protects the sellers who chose privacy.

How often do private homes come up? It varies by neighborhood and price band, and no one publishes a reliable count. What reliably improves your odds is a clear brief, proof you can close, and an agent who asks early.

What does it cost me? Buyer representation terms are agreed in writing before we tour; we'll walk through them in our first conversation.

YOUR ADVISOR

Meet Jason Kloess.



Jason Kloess is a luxury real-estate advisor with Compass RE in Nashville and the founder of Nashville Luxury List — Middle Tennessee's private resource for $1.5M+ home buyers, sellers, and relocating families.

He represents clients across Davidson and Williamson counties, with particular depth in Franklin, Brentwood, Belle Meade, Green Hills, and Leiper's Fork. His practice is built around experience earned through high-end transactions, discretion that protects his clients' privacy, and results measured in first looks, clean terms, and seamless closings.

WHAT BUYERS GET

- One-to-one access to Compass Private Exclusives and Coming Soon homes that fit your brief
- Direct outreach to listing agents and builders in your target neighborhoods
- Pricing and offer strategy grounded in current Realtracs data
- Fast private previews and live video walkthroughs
- The 2026 Nashville Luxury Buyer's Guide, with neighborhood profiles and the full buying process

SOURCES & NOTES

Where the numbers come from.

- **National Association of REALTORS®, Multiple Listing Options for Sellers** and Clear Cooperation Policy: office exclusive and delayed-marketing options, one-business-day filing rule, effective March 25, 2025, MLS implementation by September 30, 2025.
- **Compass, Private Exclusives and Coming Soon:** network description and national 2024 pre-marketing results (2.9% higher close price, 20% faster to contract, 30% less likely to take a price cut), as published by Compass with its caveats.
- **Realtracs MLS statistics report, October 19, 2026:** residential listings priced $1.5M+ in Davidson and Williamson counties — active, under contract, and closings in the last 6 months. Months of supply is our calculation.
- **Realtracs MLS via Nashville Home Guru (Compass):** $2M+ neighborhood medians, rolling 12 months, October 2026.
- **Realtracs listing exports via Nashville Homes (Gary Ashton):** months of supply by price band, June–September 2026.

A NOTE ON PRIVATE LISTINGS

Private and coming-soon listings are shared one-to-one with qualified buyers in line with NAR, Realtracs and Compass rules; nothing in this guide is an offer of any specific property. Availability of private listings varies and is not guaranteed. Figures are compiled from sources deemed reliable but are not guaranteed.

LET'S BEGIN

Get the first look.

Tell me what you're looking for, and I'll start watching for it — privately, on your timeline, without obligation.

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